

Formal symmetry Strict symmetrical and geometric beds are key to a formal design. Planting styles can be modern or traditional.

Traditional layers To achieve deep, layered schemes, create a bed that slopes slightly, and group plants in descending height order with periodic vertical interruptions.



MODERN vs. TRADITIONAL

Both formal and modernist planting schemes focus on visual effects, rather than attempting to mirror nature. Formal garden styles are rooted in the Classical architecture of Greece and Italy, and French Renaissance gardens, such as Versailles. The designs create elegant patterns with plants and present them in symmetrical beds. Parterres and knot gardens made from clipped boxwood and topiary shapes lend a sense of formality to schemes. More informal perennial plantings are also often included, but are confined to geometric beds to maintain the style. Designers who follow modernist principles adhere to the maxim that “less is more,” and use a limited palette of plants set out in geometric beds, usually rectangles. Unlike formal garden designs, modernist schemes employ asymmetry, which creates a more dynamic effect. Upright grasses and hedges are often used, and perennials are limited to just one or two varieties to create uniform blocks of color and shape.

Traditional borders, as epitomized by Gertrude Jekyll, take elements from both formal and informal styles. While contemporary perennial schemes mix plants of different heights and forms on one plane, traditional schemes are often laid out in beds on a slight incline with the tallest plants at the back and shortest in front, allowing all to be seen clearly. However, plants are not designed in formal lines but grouped in interlocking diamond-shaped swathes that reflect natural landscapes and create a sense of movement.